THEGAPBRIEF — WEEK 7 · NOVEMBER 9, 2026



Apps put something between people and what they came for. And schools that turn off Google's AI lose Search too.

Product gaps, emerging markets, kids' apps, and AI updates from November 2 – November 9, 2026.

Items are ranked within each section, most important first. Every claim links to its source; numbers appear only where a cited source states them. Review counts come from the cited review analyses, not from us.

This week's gaps share one pattern: something now stands between people and the thing they opened the app for. Amazon's search runs through Alexa with no off switch, Pinterest shows a full-screen ad when you tap a pin, and Benjamin users say the only working cash-out leads to a gambling site. Meanwhile TikTok gave its shop an app of its own, Amazon swapped Grubhub for Uber Eats in Prime, Apple set an 18+ minimum for dating features and romantic AI companions, Google said schools that switch off its AI will lose Search, and Anthropic told investors it may soon meet its own threshold for AI-accelerated progress.

- Gaps · missing pieces in real products (6)
- Markets · what is emerging (6)
- Kids · popular, growing, missing (6)
- AI · the week's key updates (6)

GAPS Missing gaps in real apps and products

Real product, the missing piece, and why nobody covers it yet.

1.1 Amazon: search now runs through Alexa, and there is no off switch

MISSING A setting for plain search results. Shoppers who type a product into the Amazon app get Alexa for Shopping (the assistant formerly called Rufus) first, and must tap through to the regular results each time. Unstar found no setting that turns it off and no Amazon instructions for doing so.

EVIDENCE Unstar read 66 Google Play reviews from November 1–5 about Alexa in search, 55 of them one-star: 28 want it off or say they can't turn it off and 20 say search is slower or doesn't load. It found 32 more one-star App Store reviews from October 31. Such complaints made up 16.0% of 1–3 star reviews in early November, up from 4.9% in late October. Amazon replied to none of the 9,000 reviews Unstar pulled.

WHY OPEN The assistant now sits in front of the results instead of beside them. Reviewers searching for an exact title say it gets in the way most, and the only workarounds are an extra tap each time or the website with a browser extension.

Unstar: Amazon Alexa search review analysis (Nov 7, 2026)

1.2 Pinterest on Android: tapping a pin can now open a full-screen ad you can't skip

MISSING A way to opt out, or to pay for no ads. Reviewers say opening a pin sometimes plays a full-screen ad with a timer before the X appears. Unstar found no setting that removes the format and no ad-free plan.

EVIDENCE Unstar counted 126 US Google Play reviews from October 26 to November 8 describing the ad, 100 of them one-star, and 59 posted on November 7 alone. 37 say they can't skip it right away; waits they name run from 5 to 30 seconds. It appears on versions 14.41.0, 14.42.0 and 14.43.0 at once, which suggests it was switched on from Pinterest's side. Unstar found none in recent iPhone reviews. Pinterest replied to none. This is a separate change from last week's board-picker item.

WHY OPEN Ads in the feed were tolerated because they could be scrolled past. An ad that blocks the pin a person just chose interrupts the core action, and reviewers say reinstalling doesn't change it.

Unstar: Pinterest full-screen ad review analysis (Nov 9, 2026)

1.3 Benjamin rewards app: PayPal and Venmo cash-outs grayed out, with a gambling site as the way out

MISSING The cash-out the listing describes. The app's store page says users can "Cash out to PayPal, Venmo, or your bank," but reviewers say those options show as "temporarily unavailable," often after a first small payout.

EVIDENCE Unstar read 130 Google Play reviews from September 1 to November 5: 103 say PayPal, Venmo or withdrawals are unavailable, and 62 say the only route out is Acebet or another betting option. 16 say Acebet requires betting the money first, 6 say it isn't available where they live, and 8 say they tried it and still couldn't get their money. These reviews rose from 6.0% of 1–3 star reviews in September to 23.8% in the first five days of November. At least nine report a payout arriving. Benjamin replied to 13 of 1,439 low-star reviews; one, on October 12, said it was "addressing the payment options issue." Unstar has not used Acebet and could not confirm its terms.

WHY OPEN Reward-app balances aren't bank deposits, and nothing tells users when a cash-out method will come back. Steering earned money into a betting site exposes it to betting.

Unstar: Benjamin cash-out review analysis (Nov 6, 2026)

1.4 Spark Driver: leaving the app to fetch a login code sends drivers back to the start

MISSING A sign-in that survives switching apps. Reviewers say that when they leave Walmart's delivery-driver app to copy an emailed code, it reloads to the first screen, sends a new code, and after a few rounds locks them out for too many attempts.

EVIDENCE Unstar found 83 US Google Play reviews from July 22 to November 1 describing the loop, 67 of them one-star, on every version from 4.43.0 to 4.51.1. 34 were trying to sign up and 17 mention a lockout. Spark replied to none of 6,000 reviews. The only workaround reviewers name is reading the code on a second device.

WHY OPEN For a gig worker, a login loop means no orders. The flow assumes the app keeps its place while the person checks email, and drivers have no other way in.

Unstar: Spark Driver code loop review analysis (Nov 4, 2026)

1.5 Google Home: Nest live view won't load, though cameras keep recording

MISSING Live video, and a clear sign of what's broken. Reviewers say the live feed spins and ends with "live view is currently not available," while alerts and recorded history still work.

EVIDENCE Unstar found 21 Google Play reviews from October 27 to November 4, 16 of them on version 4.35.25 and 4 on the newer 4.36.24.0. Six say recording or alerts still work, and four link the failure to moving cameras from the Nest app into Google Home. Google replied to 15; none called it a known issue, and one suggested trying the Google Home web portal.

WHY OPEN Owners can't tell whether the camera, the app or Google's service is at fault. The fix Google lists last, a factory reset, permanently deletes the camera's video history.

Unstar: Google Home live view review analysis (Nov 6, 2026)

1.6 McDonald's: the Monopoly section vanished while prize claims were still open

MISSING A place to enter game pieces until the rules say the game ends. The official rules let Chance Card plays run to November 8 and prize claims to November 22, but many players found the section gone on November 1.

EVIDENCE Unstar counted 48 US Google Play reviews from November 1–3 saying the section was missing, 34 of them on November 1. No new app version shipped that day. Since October 6, at least 16 reviewers say an old order receipt sits where the Monopoly banner should be, 25 say they reinstall every time they enter codes, and 7 say reinstalling cost them their login or rewards. McDonald's replied to 23 of the 48; 20 replies said to reinstall.

WHY OPEN Promotions with legal deadlines now live inside a home screen the company can change overnight. The app shows no deadline, and the fix it suggests can wipe the rewards it is meant to restore.

Unstar: McDonald's Monopoly review analysis (Nov 5, 2026)

MARKETS Emerging markets in apps and digital products

What is actually showing up: new categories, rounds, launches, and the forces creating demand.

2.1 Social commerce gets its own app: TikTok Shop launches standalone

On November 5, TechCrunch reported that TikTok quietly launched a standalone TikTok Shop app on iOS and Android in Singapore, Malaysia, Thailand and the Philippines. It offers shopping through livestreams and short videos, app-exclusive deals, in-app checkout, order tracking and customer support. TikTok didn't comment, and it isn't known whether the app will come to the US.

TechCrunch (Nov 5, 2026)

2.2 Memberships as bundles: Prime swaps Grubhub for Uber Eats, and Uber adds parking

On November 5, Amazon made Uber Eats the restaurant delivery partner for US Prime members, ending its Grubhub deal that day. Members can order through Amazon.com and the Amazon app without an Uber account and pay no delivery fee on orders over $25; those who already activated Grubhub+ keep it through December 31, 2027. On November 9, Uber launched parking reservations in 15 US cities, using the network of 13,000 garages, lots and valet services it gained with SpotHero. Uber says Uber One had more than 55 million members as of September 30.

TechCrunch on Prime and Uber Eats (Nov 5, 2026) · TechCrunch on Uber parking (Nov 9, 2026)

2.3 Microdrama apps draw studio money in India

On November 3, EloElo, which runs the microdrama app Story TV, raised an $80 million Series C from Hornbill Capital and NBCUniversal at a $500 million valuation. TechCrunch, citing analysts, says more than 118 million people in India watch microdramas monthly and Story TV has more than 33 million active users. Paying is the open question: Redseer says more than 40 million people have paid at least once but 15–17 million pay monthly, and an Ormax Media survey found 72% have never paid.

TechCrunch (Nov 3, 2026)

2.4 App-first banks move into US banking: Revolut at $115 billion

On November 4, a secondary share sale valued Revolut at $115 billion, 53% above a year earlier; no new money went to the company. Revolut has conditional approval from the US Office of the Comptroller of the Currency for a national bank it plans to open in the first half of 2027, subject to final approval. It says it has more than 80 million retail customers and over 800,000 business customers, and that nearly half of new US business customers are newly incorporated companies.

TechCrunch (Nov 4, 2026)

2.5 Consumer subscriptions split into cheaper and add-on tiers

On its November 2 earnings call, Match Group said Hinge is testing a cheaper plan with extra filters and custom location boundaries, aimed at women and price-sensitive users; it didn't give a price. Its CFO said Hinge's revenue per payer, around $30, is almost twice Tinder's. On November 4, Snap said it passed 30 million paid subscribers across Snapchat+, Memories Storage and Lens+, up 5 million since February; Lens+ costs $8.99 a month and the ad-free Platinum tier $15.99.

TechCrunch on Hinge (Nov 2, 2026) · TechCrunch on Snapchat (Nov 4, 2026)

2.6 Taste-tracking apps for books, films and music draw buyers and launches

On November 5, The New York Times reported its parent company is in exclusive talks to buy Letterboxd for $330 million; TechCrunch says Letterboxd grew from 3 million users in January 2021 to 28 million by April. On November 2, Readwise launched Readwise Books, an e-book store and reading tracker it calls "a cross between Kindle and the Goodreads apps," with a public API. On November 9, Samsung's Harman launched Drops in the US, an invite-only app for sharing 10–30 second song clips that pays rights holders and counts plays toward streams on partner services.

TechCrunch on Letterboxd (Nov 5, 2026) · TechCrunch on Readwise Books (Nov 2, 2026) · TechCrunch on Drops (Nov 9, 2026)

KIDS Kids' apps: popular, growing, missing

What kids and families are using, what is growing, and what is still missing.

3.1 Popular: YouTube Kids still leads free, Toca Boca World now leads grossing

POPULAR In Appfigures' hourly US iPhone Kids chart (checked November 9), the top four free apps are unchanged: YouTube Kids, Toca Boca World, LEGO Builder and Lingokids. ABCmouse moved up to fifth, and Bluey: Let's Play! slipped to eighth; Messenger Kids is 11th. Toca Boca World has overtaken Lingokids for top grossing, with Learn to Read (Reading.com) third and Bluey fourth. Stack the States is still the top paid app, followed by Teach Your Monster to Read. Rankings change hourly and are not download counts.

Appfigures: Top Kids Apps, US iPhone

3.2 Demand driver: Apple sets 18+ for dating features and romantic AI companions

WHAT CHANGED On November 2, Apple said App Store Connect will add two age-rating descriptors on November 16. Apps with "Dating and Relationships" features, meaning connections between real people or a virtual companion that engages users in sexual or romantic content, get a minimum 18+ rating. Apps must also declare "Shared Location" features. Every app must complete the declarations by January 12, 2027. In Brazil, location sharing requires an A16 rating, though family location apps can ask the government for a lower one.

WHY IT MATTERS A rating is a label, not an age check. General chat apps with a romantic mode now have to decide whether to drop the feature, split the app, or go 18+.

Apple Developer News (Nov 2, 2026) · TechCrunch (Nov 3, 2026)

3.3 Missing: school search without AI

MISSING On November 3, Google said its AI tools will be off by default for K-12 students next year unless administrators turn them on, but a school that restricts AI altogether will lose Google Search, because "Search and AI are deeply integrated." After criticism from senators and others, Google said Gemini, NotebookLM and Search would be off by default and could be enabled one by one. On November 4, DuckDuckGo pitched schools on switching their default search engine, pointing to its noai.duckduckgo.com site with AI answers turned off.

WHY OPEN Teachers want students to find sources without AI summaries in the way. Google's plan offers no Search without them.

TechCrunch on Google's plan (Nov 3, 2026) · TechCrunch on the backlash (Nov 4, 2026) · TechCrunch on DuckDuckGo (Nov 4, 2026)

3.4 Demand driver: Meta, Google and TikTok sue to block California's under-16 feed law

WHAT CHANGED On November 5, the three companies sued California's attorney general over AB 1709, which takes effect at the start of the new year. It bars autoplay and personalized feeds for users under 16 and requires platforms to delete their accounts if those features aren't turned off, with fines of up to $50,000 per affected user. The companies argue it violates the First Amendment and is preempted by Section 230; the EFF says it forces more data collection from every user. Separately, on November 2 Snap settled a lawsuit by two teenagers who said its design fed their depression and eating disorders.

WHY IT MATTERS If the law survives, platforms would have to switch off autoplay and personalized feeds for under-16s in California, which means first working out who is under 16.

TechCrunch on AB 1709 (Nov 5, 2026) · TechCrunch on Snap settlement (Nov 2, 2026)

3.5 Growing: Instagram's AI age estimation goes worldwide

GROWING On November 9, Meta said it is expanding its AI age estimation on Instagram to all countries, to find teens who gave an adult birthday and move them into Teen Accounts, which are private by default and limit who can message them. It looks for clues such as birthday posts or school grades, and visual cues in photos and videos. The rollout continues on Facebook, with Threads planned later this year. Meta ties the work to its agreement with 52 attorneys general, under which it committed to better identify teens and children under 13.

TechCrunch (Nov 9, 2026)

3.6 Growing: phones built for kids, with the controls in the parent's app

GROWING A November 7 TechCrunch survey of the kid-phone market lists devices that remove or lock browsers, social media and app stores, managed from a parent's companion app. Bark Phone costs $240 plus plans from $29 a month and scans messages and photos for risks; Gabb starts around $159.99 with service from about $24.99 a month and leaves out social media and a browser; Pinwheel starts around $119 with a $14.99 monthly caregiver subscription and lets parents set modes for school hours.

TechCrunch (Nov 7, 2026)

AI The most important AI updates this week

What changed and why it matters.

4.1 Anthropic tells investors it may soon meet its own threshold for AI-accelerated progress

WHAT CHANGED In its amended S-1 filed November 2, Anthropic added risk factors saying that its internal estimates for future models indicate it "may imminently meet" its Responsible Scaling Policy's definition of "dramatically accelerated progress attributable to AI," and that it has in the past not recognized leaps in capability until after they happened. It says no current model has crossed the threshold, and that it is considering policy updates to keep humans in control of frontier model development.

WHY IT MATTERS A securities filing is a disclosure with legal weight, though TechCrunch notes an S-1 also works as marketing.

TechCrunch (Nov 2, 2026)

4.2 OpenAI releases ChatGPT Cyber as AI-found bugs pile up

WHAT CHANGED On November 5, OpenAI made a security-focused model, ChatGPT Cyber, available to the top tier of its Daybreak program for vetted security researchers. A day earlier it said the model scanned the Linux kernel and found 948 potential issues, and found 81 new vulnerabilities in Firefox. It also announced a $1 billion initiative for defenders of critical infrastructure.

WHY IT MATTERS Finding bugs is getting faster than fixing them. TechCrunch says defenders feel the labs have created more work than they have resources for.

TechCrunch (Nov 5, 2026)

4.3 Uber says four rides came from AI agents in its busiest week, as Amazon builds its own

WHAT CHANGED *New development* on Week 6's agent-shopping item. On its November 4 earnings call, Uber said only four rides were ordered by an AI agent in the week of Halloween, and about 500 Uber Eats orders, out of roughly 320 million trips and orders. On November 6, Amazon began letting select US customers shop by texting Alexa, after blocking Meta's Muse agent from its site in September.

WHY IT MATTERS Outside agents are barely used so far, and the big platforms are building their own instead of opening up to others.

TechCrunch on Uber (Nov 4, 2026) · TechCrunch on Amazon (Nov 6, 2026)

4.4 Claude connects to bank accounts, read-only

WHAT CHANGED On November 5, Anthropic launched Personal Finance in Claude. Users link bank and card accounts through Plaid and ask about spending; Claude can flag duplicate charges, unexpected fees and rising bills. Anthropic says access is read-only, covers balances and up to two years of transactions, and that chats in the Personal Finance hub aren't used for training. ChatGPT added similar tools in May.

WHY IT MATTERS Chat assistants are moving into money questions that budgeting apps used to own, with read-only access as the line they won't cross yet.

TechCrunch (Nov 5, 2026)

4.5 Ramp data: business AI spending flattened even as usage rose

WHAT CHANGED A November 6 report from Ramp shows company spending on AI tokens grew only 1.5% across August and September, after 42% month-over-month growth in July; it rose 8.9% from September 23 to October 23. Ramp's economist Ara Kharazian points to price cuts: OpenAI halved some API prices in September, and Anthropic says in a filing that its own price reductions cut revenue growth by about $600 million.

WHY IT MATTERS AI is getting cheaper to buy faster than companies are using more of it, which is good for buyers and harder for labs heading to public markets.

TechCrunch (Nov 6, 2026)

4.6 Security companies buy tools for watching AI agents

WHAT CHANGED On November 3, CrowdStrike said it will buy Fiddler AI, which monitors AI agents inside companies, and Dreadnode, which tests AI models and agents for flaws; The Wall Street Journal put the prices at about $400 million and $95 million. On November 5, TechCrunch reported that Palo Alto Networks is in talks to buy Clutch Security, which secures agents' access to company systems, for $500 million in cash plus milestone payments, according to a person familiar with the talks.

WHY IT MATTERS Companies are deploying agents faster than their security tools can see what those agents do, and the largest vendors are buying that visibility rather than building it.

TechCrunch on CrowdStrike (Nov 3, 2026) · TechCrunch on Palo Alto Networks (Nov 5, 2026)

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